

# Summary

Narrative value is strongest when it helps players stay positive despite friction.

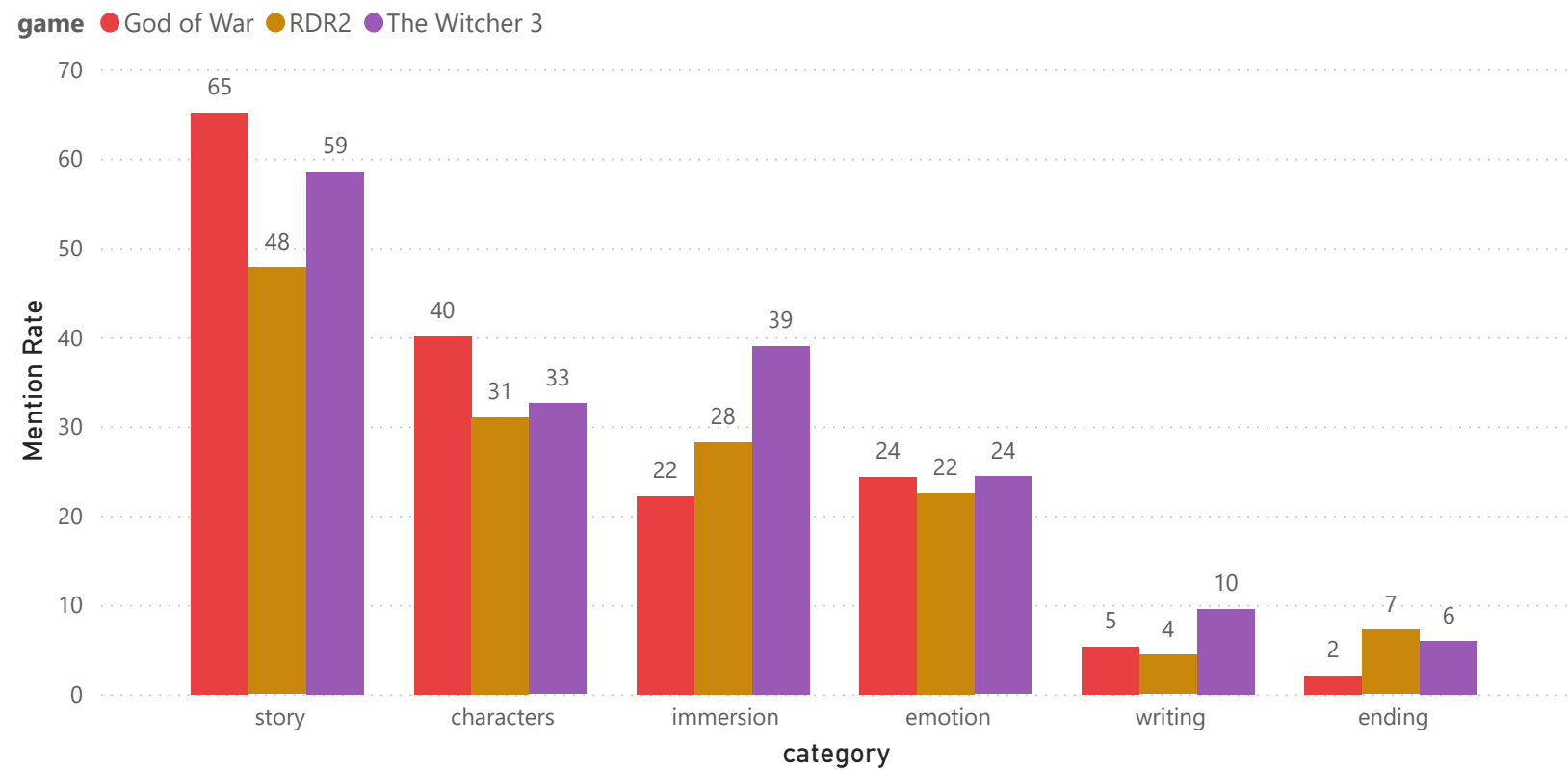
This report analyses English-language Steam reviews for three narrative-driven action RPGs: God of War, Red Dead Redemption 2, and The Witcher 3: Wild Hunt. The goal is to understand how narrative elements shape player sentiment, and whether strong storytelling can help offset perceived gameplay weaknesses.

The dataset was collected from Steam reviews, with approximately 5,000 raw English-language reviews per game. Reviews were then filtered to players with 10+ hours of playtime and review text of 20+ words, to focus on players with meaningful exposure to the game experience.

Sentiment is based on Steam's recommendation label: "recommended" reviews are treated as positive, while "not recommended" reviews are treated as negative. Python was used to detect narrative-related keywords and themes in review text, including story, characters, emotion, immersion, writing, and ending.

Gameplay flaw reviews were identified through keyword matching for commonly mentioned friction points such as combat, controls, pacing, difficulty, repetition, and technical issues. Power BI was used to compare narrative mention rates, positive review lift, and compensation gaps between positive and negative flaw-mentioning reviews.

# Narrative Profile by Game



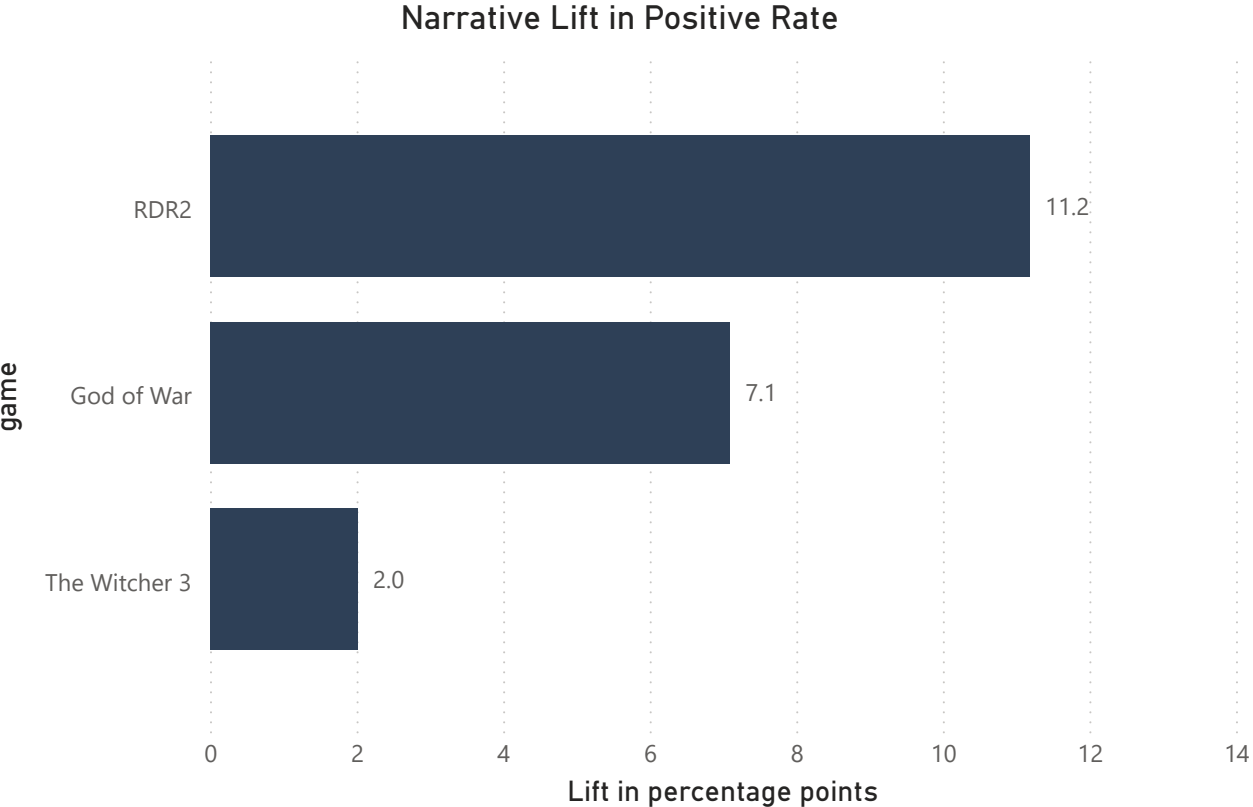
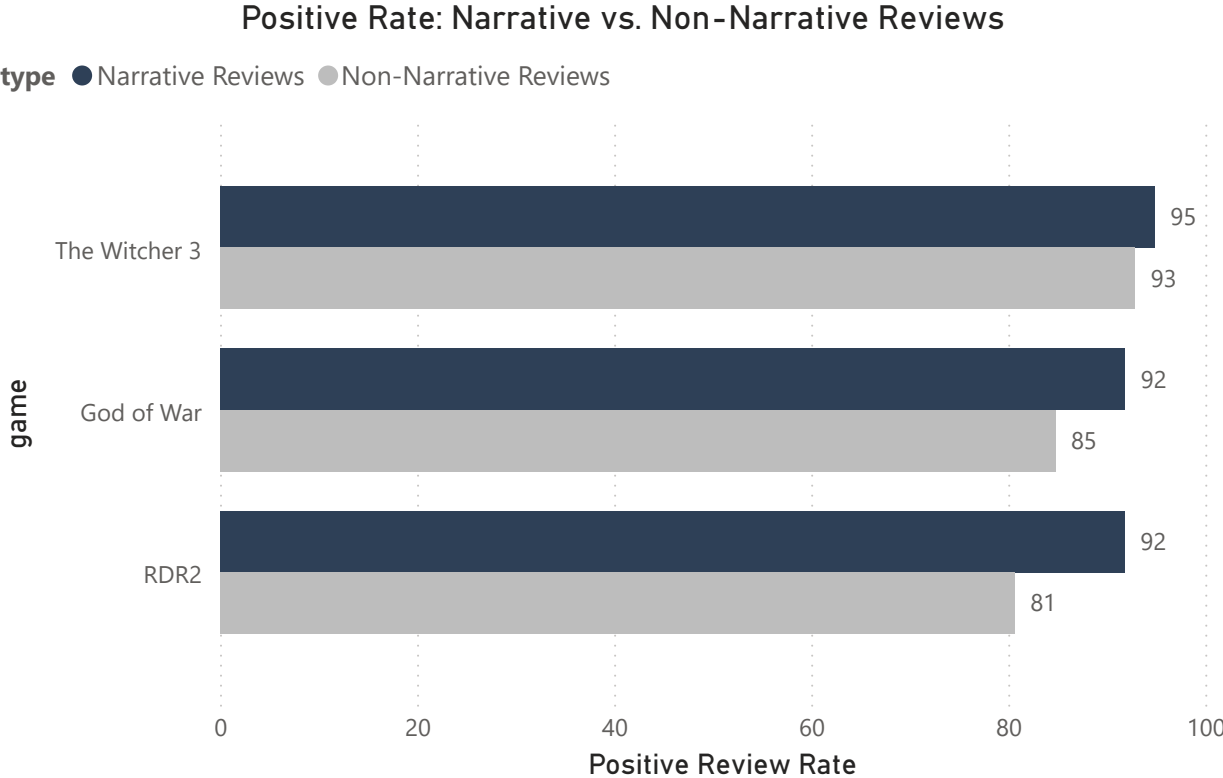
## Key Findings

Story is the strongest narrative signal across all three games, appearing in 48-65% of positive reviews. This makes story the most consistent driver of narrative-related satisfaction.

**God of War** has the clearest character-led profile: 40% of positive reviews mention characters, the highest among the three games, reflecting the importance of the Kratos-Atreus relationship.

**The Witcher 3** stands out for immersion, with 39% of positive reviews mentioning world and immersion. **RDR2** sits between the two, with a more balanced profile across story, characters, immersion, and emotion.

# Narrative Helps Most When Gameplay Is More Divisive



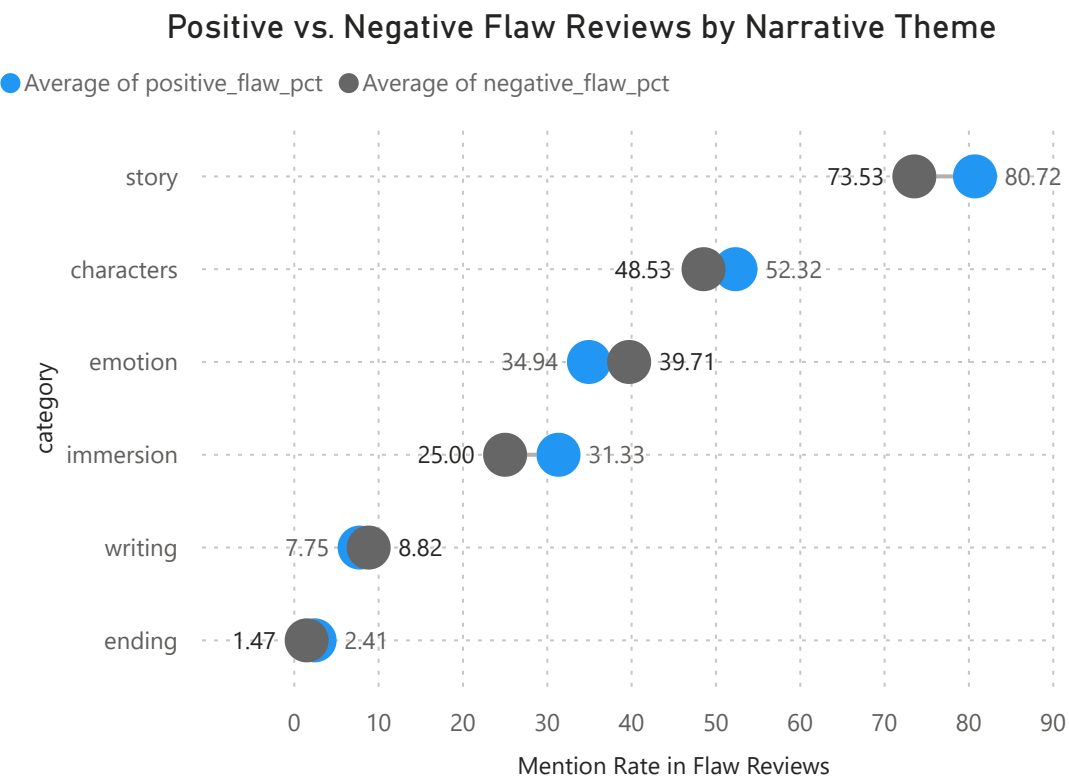
## Key Findings

**RDR2** shows the strongest narrative lift: reviews mentioning narrative elements are 11.2 percentage points more likely to be positive than non-narrative reviews.

**God of War** also shows a meaningful lift (+7.1pp), suggesting story and character engagement strengthen satisfaction even when players discuss other parts of the experience.

**The Witcher 3** has the smallest lift (+2.0pp), not because narrative is weak, but because non-narrative reviews are already highly positive. Its baseline satisfaction is high across both groups.

# Narrative as a Satisfaction Buffer



Narrative Compensation Gap by Game

| game       | characters | emotion | ending | immersion | story | writing |
|------------|------------|---------|--------|-----------|-------|---------|
| God of War | 3.79       | -4.77   | 0.94   | 6.33      | 7.19  | -1.07   |

Gap = positive flaw reviews - negative flaw reviews

- game
- God of War
  - RDR2
  - The Witcher 3

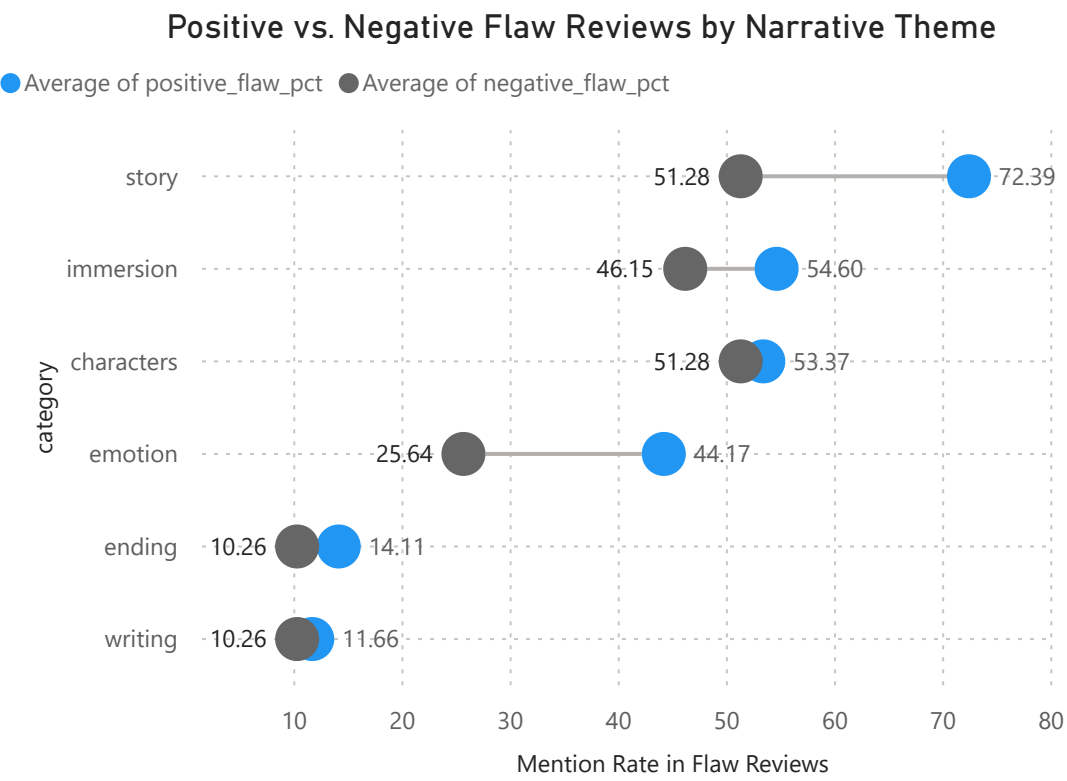
## Key Findings

**RDR2's** compensation effect is driven by story and emotion, suggesting that emotional attachment helps players forgive friction elsewhere in the experience.

**The Witcher 3** shows the strongest story gap, supported by characters and immersion, meaning its world and cast keep players invested even when gameplay flaws are mentioned.

**God of War** shows smaller and mixed gaps, suggesting narrative works more as a complement than a rescue mechanism.

# Narrative as a Satisfaction Buffer



Narrative Compensation Gap by Game

| game | characters | emotion | ending | immersion | story | writing |
|------|------------|---------|--------|-----------|-------|---------|
| RDR2 | 2.09       | 18.53   | 3.85   | 8.45      | 21.11 | 1.40    |

Gap = positive flaw reviews - negative flaw reviews

- game
- God of War
  - RDR2
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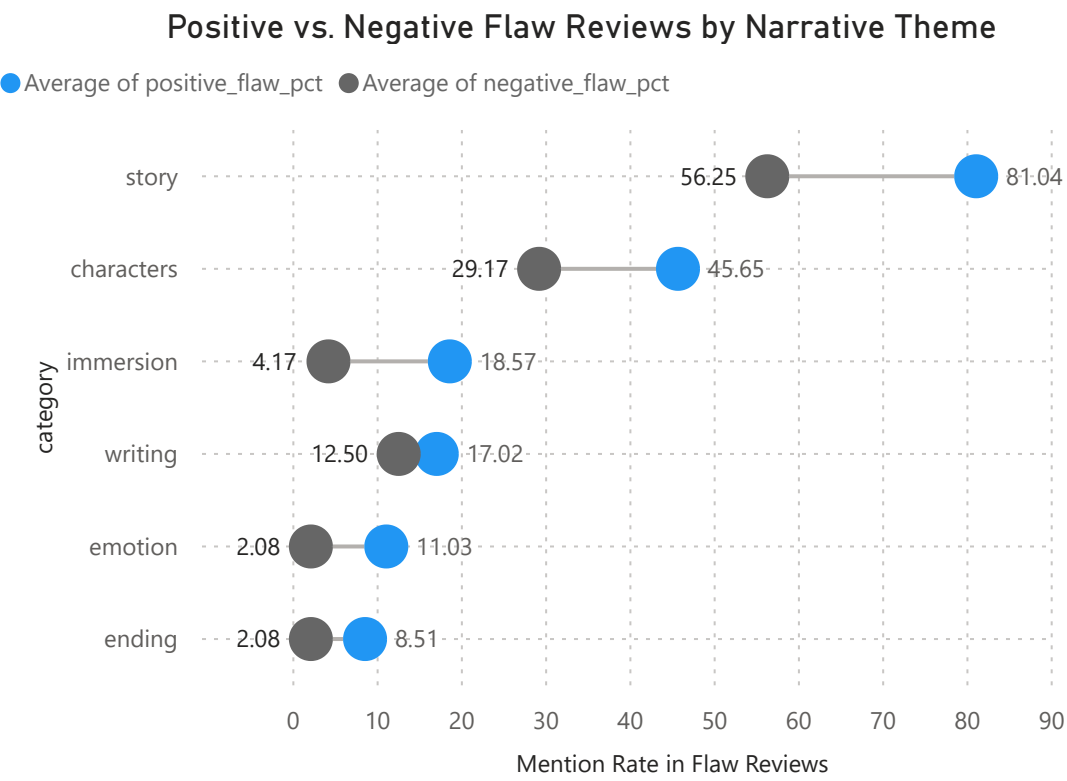
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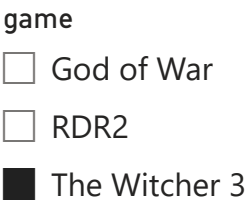
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# Narrative as a Satisfaction Buffer



| Narrative Compensation Gap by Game |            |         |        |           |       |         |
|------------------------------------|------------|---------|--------|-----------|-------|---------|
| game                               | characters | emotion | ending | immersion | story | writing |
| The Witcher 3                      | 16.48      | 8.95    | 6.43   | 14.40     | 24.79 | 4.52    |

Gap = positive flaw reviews - negative flaw reviews



## Key Findings

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# Conclusions

## Three Games, Three Narrative Identities

**God of War** is the most character-led. Story and characters dominate positive reviews, with 65% and 40% mention rates respectively. However, its compensation gaps are smaller and more mixed, suggesting narrative acts more as a complement to an already strong gameplay baseline than as a rescue mechanism.

**Red Dead Redemption 2** shows the strongest emotional buffer. It has the largest narrative lift in positive review rate (+11.2pp), and positive flaw reviews are much more likely to mention story (+21.1pp) and emotion (+18.5pp) than negative flaw reviews. This suggests Arthur Morgan's story helps players tolerate friction around pacing, controls, or mechanical feel.

**The Witcher 3** is defined by world and immersion. It has the highest immersion mention rate in positive reviews (39%) and the strongest story compensation gap (+24.8pp), supported by characters (+16.5pp) and immersion (+14.4pp). Its world and cast appear to keep players invested even when gameplay flaws are mentioned.

**The common thread:** players can forgive flaws when the game gives them something meaningful to hold onto, whether that is character attachment, emotional payoff, or a world they want to inhabit.

**Method limitation:** This analysis uses Steam recommendation labels and keyword-based theme detection. Keyword extraction may miss synonyms, sarcasm, implicit praise or criticism, and context-dependent meanings, so theme counts and compensation gaps should be treated as directional signals rather than exhaustive measurements.